

Decision to Attack

The combination of US withdrawal, the relative inexperience of ARVN troops in combat, and antiwar opinions in the US created a window of opportunity for North Vietnam. In the spring of 1972, it decided to act.

◀◀ BEFORE

At the end of 1971, Hanoi was in a strong position, especially after the ARVN failure in Lam Son.

RECOVERING FROM TET

North Vietnam's failed **Tet Offensive** decimated Viet Cong forces, but they were replenished through continued infiltration along the Ho Chi Minh Trail. The failure of South Vietnam's **Operation Lam Son 719** in Laos in early 1971 revealed the weakness of ARVN forces.



VIET CONG IN ACTION IN 1968

In the latter half of 1971, the North Vietnamese Politburo began to make plans for a major new offensive into South Vietnam for spring 1972. It was to be a campaign unlike anything they had tried before, with troops waging conventional warfare, employing massed tanks and heavy artillery. The North Vietnamese planned to coordinate closely among main force, regional, and local troops and to fight in urban and rural areas alike; unlike the Tet Offensive, which had unfolded in waves, the attack would be relentless. Diplomacy would proceed in parallel.

Supplies and training

Hanoi's allies, China and the Soviet Union, had scheduled talks with American leaders in 1972. Anxious to cushion the shock these diplomatic openings might cause Hanoi, they supplied North Vietnam with additional increments of military aid. China tripled shipments of artillery guns, sending nearly 7,900 pieces to Hanoi in 1971 alone, and delivered 300 tanks between 1971 and 1972. Moscow also sent tanks, along with modern cannons and more sophisticated missiles, such as the shoulder-fired SA-7 "Strella" antiaircraft weapon and the AT-3 "Sagger" antitank missile.